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The economy of Hausa communities of Zaria

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A. Kinship terminology and behaviour • Chapter 4 The Wider Field of Kinship

Chapter 4 The Wider Field of Kinship

A. Kinship terminology and behaviour

The Hausa term for kinship is dangintaka. The term dangi denotes kinsfolk. The dangin uba is the kin of the father, the dangin uwa is the kin of the mother. Hausa kinship is bilateral in its range, but the ties with the father's kin (dangin uba) are of a different kind from those with the mother's kin (dangin uwa). As shown above, agnatic kinship forms the basis for the great majority of Hausa domestic groupings, and agnatic kinship is traced through the father. The term dangi denotes a cognatic group, and the [unavailable] element which is distinguished for residential and certain other purposes within this cognatic group is a product of virilocal marriage, differential division of inheritance as between males and females on the one hand, and agnatic and uterine kin on the other, in Maliki law ^{*}, and also of the virtual disappearance of agnatic lineages among the contemporary Hausa as a result of the conversion to Islam of the aboriginal Hausa-speaking peoples of the Western Sudan. ^{**} Before these and other aspects of Hausa kinship can be considered, it is necessary to give an account of the terminology and associated behavioural norms.

178
[Sociocultural Trends](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

The system of kinship terminology and relationship used by the Hausa, and set out in the following diagram (p. 42) is of the type known to anthropologists as classificatory, and uses as its differentiating and classifying principles factors of generation, sex, seniority by birth, and patrilineal or matrilineal relationship. The range of these various

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

differentiating principles is not identical. The terms used between siblings to distinguish relative seniority are not always applied to collaterals of the same generation who are not members of the speaker's domestic unit. Ego's cross-cousins of either sex are his abokan wasa (joking relations), and there is not much difference in the affective or social content of the relationships between go and his paternal or maternal grandparents. In the diagram of kinship [unavailable], no distinction is made between full and half siblings. Full siblings describe themselves as "'yan uwa sosai, uba daya, uwa daya" - "true siblings, [unavailable] father, one mother" or "dakimmu daya" - "of one hut", i.e. one mother, and differentiate themselves from half-siblings as follows: "uba daya, uwa [unavailable] da nashi" - "one father, each his own mother", or "uwa daya, uba kowa da [unavailable]" - "one mother, each his own father". The social importance of the [unavailable]-sibling relationship and its difference from that of full siblings has been mentioned in the context of household composition, and will be returned [unavailable] later.

A high degree of variability in the observance of certain of the norms of kinship behaviour is found, and although these variations can usually be explained [unavailable] in terms of the social situation and interests of the persons involved, it is simplest to classify and describe the different norms of [unavailable] behaviour, as defined by the ideal pattern, before proceeding to a [unavailable] of variability in their observance and other general aspects of the system.

602
Kin Relationships

Hausa distinguish four different norms of behaviour to be observed between clearly specified categories of kin. 1) The discipline-respect relationship. 2) The avoidance-shame relationship (kunya). 3) The [unavailable] relationship (zumunta). 4) The joking relationship (wasas).

602
Kin Relationships

Discipline-respect relationships are observed between parents, lineal [unavailable] collateral, and children, lineal and collateral, except in the cases where [unavailable] fondness relationship holds, and also between real or classificatory senior and junior siblings of the same sex.

602
Kin Relationships

[unavailable] op. cit., pp. 373-397, especially p. 375 footnote (tabular statement of the shares) and pp. 385-7.

[unavailable] J.H., Islam and Clan Organization among the Housa, Southwestern Journal of Anthropology, Vol. 3 1947. pp. 193-211.

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